

GRE Vocabulary Notes: Group 29

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1. Abscond

Meaning: To run away secretly, especially to avoid arrest or responsibility.

Tip to remember: Abscond sounds like “absent and gone.” If someone absconds, they disappear secretly.

Sentence: The accountant absconded with the company’s money.

2. Apogee

Meaning: The highest point or peak of something.

Tip to remember: In astronomy, apogee is the farthest point from Earth. In GRE, it means the highest point of success.

Sentence: Winning the international award was the apogee of her career.

3. Aspersion

Meaning: A damaging or critical remark about someone’s reputation.

Tip to remember: Think of throwing dirt on someone’s image. That dirt is an aspersion.

Sentence: The article cast aspersions on the scientist’s integrity.

4. Bawdy

Meaning: Humorously indecent or vulgar.

Tip to remember: Bawdy sounds like “body.” Bawdy jokes are often vulgar jokes about the body.

Sentence: The comedian’s bawdy jokes offended some members of the audience.

5. Chagrin

Meaning: Embarrassment or annoyance caused by failure or disappointment.

Tip to remember: Think of your face dropping when you make a silly mistake in public. That feeling is chagrin.

Sentence: To his chagrin, he forgot the answer during the interview.

6. Collude

Meaning: To secretly cooperate for a dishonest or illegal purpose.

Tip to remember: Collude sounds like “cooperate in a rude way.” It means secret dishonest cooperation.

Sentence: The companies colluded to raise prices unfairly.

7. **Commiserate**
Meaning: To express sympathy or share someone's sadness.
Tip to remember: Commiserate contains "misery." You share someone's misery with sympathy.
Sentence: His friends commiserated with him after he lost the match.
8. **Conflagration**
Meaning: A large destructive fire; also, a major conflict.
Tip to remember: Think of a huge fire consuming a forest. That is a conflagration.
Sentence: The conflagration destroyed several houses in the village.
9. **Contretemps**
Meaning: An embarrassing or awkward disagreement or incident.
Tip to remember: Think of a small social accident at the wrong time. That awkward moment is a contretemps.
Sentence: A minor contretemps over seating delayed the meeting.
10. **Conviction**
Meaning: A strong belief; also, a formal declaration that someone is guilty of a crime.
Tip to remember: GRE trick: conviction can mean strong belief or legal guilt.
Sentence: She spoke with conviction about the need for clean energy.
11. **Croon**
Meaning: To sing softly and gently.
Tip to remember: Think of someone softly singing a lullaby. That is crooning.
Sentence: The singer crooned a gentle song to the audience.
12. **Depose**
Meaning: To remove someone from power; also, to give sworn testimony.
Tip to remember: Depose sounds like "de-position." To depose a ruler is to remove them from their position.
Sentence: The rebels tried to depose the dictator.
13. **Detente**
Meaning: A relaxation of tension between countries or groups.
Tip to remember: Think of two enemies lowering their weapons and reducing tension. That is detente.
Sentence: The peace talks created a period of detente between the two nations.
14. **Dowdy**
Meaning: Unfashionable, dull, or not stylish in appearance.
Tip to remember: Dowdy sounds like "dull body." A dowdy outfit looks dull and old-fashioned.
Sentence: He wore a dowdy coat to the formal event.
15. **Echelon**
Meaning: A level or rank in an organization or society.

Tip to remember: Think of a ladder with different levels. Each level is an echelon.
Sentence: She rose to the highest echelon of the company.

16. **Ennui**

Meaning: Boredom and dissatisfaction from lack of excitement.

Tip to remember: Ennui sounds like “any we?” Imagine being so bored that even conversation feels dull.

Sentence: After months of routine work, he felt a deep sense of ennui.

17. **Expatiate**

Meaning: To speak or write at length about a topic.

Tip to remember: Expatiate sounds like “expand.” If you expatiate, you expand on an idea in detail.

Sentence: The professor expatiated on the importance of power system reliability.

18. **Fraught**

Meaning: Filled with something negative, such as danger, tension, or difficulty.

Tip to remember: Think of a road filled with traps. It is fraught with danger.

Sentence: The negotiation was fraught with tension.

19. **Fulcrum**

Meaning: The point on which something balances or turns; a central support.

Tip to remember: In a lever, the fulcrum is the support point. In GRE, it can mean the central point of influence.

Sentence: Education is the fulcrum of social progress.

20. **Imbroglio**

Meaning: A confused, complicated, or embarrassing situation.

Tip to remember: Imbroglio sounds messy and tangled. Think of a political mess with many people involved.

Sentence: The leaked emails created a serious political imbroglio.

21. **Jocund**

Meaning: Cheerful and lighthearted.

Tip to remember: Jocund sounds like “joke.” A jocund person is happy and joking.

Sentence: The jocund crowd celebrated the festival with music and dance.

22. **Languish**

Meaning: To become weak, neglected, or fail to make progress.

Tip to remember: Languish sounds like “low energy.” If a project languishes, it sits weakly without progress.

Sentence: The proposal languished for months without approval.

23. **Nadir**

Meaning: The lowest point of something.

Tip to remember: Nadir is the opposite of zenith. Zenith is the top; nadir is the bottom.

Sentence: Losing the final match was the nadir of the team’s season.

24. **Nimble**
Meaning: Quick, light, and skillful in movement or thought.
Tip to remember: Think of a cat jumping quickly from place to place. A cat is nimble.
Sentence: A nimble mind can solve GRE problems quickly.
25. **Ominous**
Meaning: Suggesting that something bad is likely to happen.
Tip to remember: Ominous sounds like “omen.” A bad omen is ominous.
Sentence: The dark clouds looked ominous before the storm.
26. **Outlandish**
Meaning: Very strange, unusual, or shocking.
Tip to remember: Think of something from an “out land,” far away and strange.
Sentence: His outlandish costume attracted everyone’s attention.
27. **Propitious**
Meaning: Favorable or likely to bring success.
Tip to remember: Propitious sounds like “proper position.” When everything is in the proper position, success is likely.
Sentence: The clear weather was propitious for the mountain trip.
28. **Prurient**
Meaning: Having or encouraging excessive interest in sexual matters.
Tip to remember: Think of someone being improperly curious about private matters. That interest is prurient.
Sentence: The article was criticized for its prurient tone.
29. **Sadistic**
Meaning: Enjoying cruelty or the suffering of others.
Tip to remember: A sadistic person feels satisfaction from making others sad or hurt.
Sentence: The sadistic guard enjoyed frightening the prisoners.
30. **Zenith**
Meaning: The highest point or peak.
Tip to remember: Zenith is the opposite of nadir. Zenith means the top; nadir means the bottom.
Sentence: The scientist reached the zenith of his career after winning the Nobel Prize.